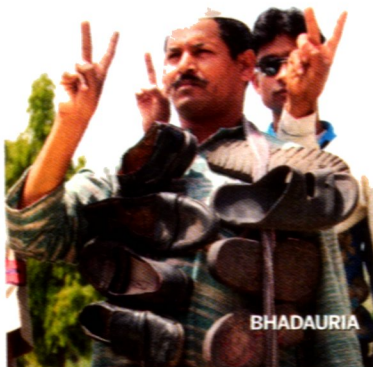


SHOEMAN

A series of shoe-hurling incidents has turned many politicians 'footwear-phobic'. But Naresh Bhadauria, an independent candidate contesting from Amritsar, thinks differently. He wears a garland of shoes, chappals and other footwear when he goes while

SHAL KUMAR



BHADAURIA

campaigning. His reason for the indulgence? "This is what most leaders deserve." Bhadauria, an advocate from Uttar Pradesh, says he is in politics "to loot people and make money". Not many may take him seriously, but in a star-studded contest that has former cricketer Navjot Singh Sidhu in the fray, this trick may just do the needful.

by Arvind Chhabra

Tough GOING

ASBANT NEGI



LALU

In politics, change is the only constant. And Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief Lalu Prasad Yadav is experiencing it all in the middle of the toughest election race of his career. The two men who have challenged him in Patliputra constituency are his former lieutenants. Arch rival Nitish Kumar has fielded Ranjan Prasad Yadav while friend-turned-foe Congress has sent Vijay Singh Yadav. Ranjan was once considered Lalu's 'friend, philosopher and guide', while Vijay was a loyalist. Worse still, Lalu's estranged brother-in-law Sadhu Yadav is extensively canvassing for the Congress candidate. Having had a tough fight against BJP nominee Rajiv Pratap Rudy in Saran constituency on April 16, the going seems even tougher for him this time.

by Amitabh Srivastava

60

thousand individuals have been identified by the Election Commission as miscreants in Phase IV of the elections.

Edge of the Seats

The upcoming polls in Rajasthan will prove to be testing times for both Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot and his rival Vasundhara Raje. Gehlot, who got 96 of 200 seats in the Assembly elections in December last year, will be delighted if he repeats his feat. Raje, on her part, would obviously wish that the Congress slide down to a single digit. But it's not just the two of them whose political careers are at stake. Famous for his one-vote Assembly poll defeat in Nathdwara, state Congress chief C.P. Joshi would be eyeing a victory that may land him a ministry at the Centre if the Congress returns to power.

by Rohit Parihar



PURUSHOTTAM DIMAKAR

GEHLOT